

communities, before turning up in western Japan (northern Kyushu) in the ninth century BCE and then spreading discontinuously across eastern Japan (Leipe et al. 2020). What drove that timing, Leipe and colleagues argue, was less anything happening within Japan than geopolitical upheaval on the Asian mainland. The eastward expansion of the Shang and Zhou dynasties in China, combined with a mid-to-late Holocene decline in summer monsoon precipitation that hurt agricultural yields near the middle Yellow River, pushed early rice-farming populations first onto the Korean peninsula and then, by around 1000 BCE, into Japan (Leipe et al. 2020). Rice's arrival in the Jomon world, understood this way, was not a local innovation or proof of superior productivity. It was the archaeological signature of a chain of migrations triggered by political and climatic pressure thousands of kilometers away.

Even after immigrant rice farmers reached the archipelago, the archaeological record makes clear that rice cultivation did not simply replace Jomon foraging on arrival. Horiuchi and colleagues' combined stable isotope and organic residue analysis of Final Jomon Kamegaoka culture pottery, dated to the centuries just before the conventional Jomon–Yayoi boundary, found chemical signatures consistent with the continued processing of marine and terrestrial foods in cooking vessels, with no clear evidence that cultivated starches had yet displaced these resources at the sites studied (Horiuchi et al. 2015). This fits the broader pattern archaeologist Bruce Smith termed “low-level food production”: a long middle ground between pure foraging and full agricultural dependence, in which cultivated and wild resources are exploited side by side, sometimes for centuries, before agriculture comes to supply the bulk of a community's calories (Smith 2001). Kazunobu Ikeya's ethnoarchaeological analysis of the Jomon-to-Yayoi transition argues that this gradual absorption was possible because incoming rice cultivation was folded into existing patterns of settlement and social organization, rather than requiring wholesale

Alexander Dorr
Aug 4 at 8:34 PM

Good. I think you need to acknowledge the demographic element of your thesis *much* sooner.

Alexander Dorr
Aug 4 at 8:34 PM

Yep, the populations intermingled rather than a straight up replacement event